

Light Infantry Tactical Adaptation Under Persistent ISR & Fires



UGS/UAS reshaping infantry battle drills

Mission command under continuous visibility

Image: AI generated juxtaposition of [Lostbulgaria.com](https://lostbulgaria.com) (n.d.) still image of Bulgarian storm troopers (2017) and video footage of Chosen Company of the International Legion in the attack in Donetsk (2023)

SPEECH

Russo-Ukrainian War: Why it Matters

Laboratory Context

Ukraine is a vignette, not a template · clearest contemporary example of peer conflict under dense ISR

Caveat: Soviet AD denied manned air → UAS for local superiority

Caveat: Western preference is manoeuvre warfare & avoid attritional warfare

Core Constraint

Concentration becomes lethal

Visibility precedes destruction, echoing WWI's machine-gun logic

Close proximity limits manoeuvre and 'manoeuvrist' approaches

■raining Focus

Reveals constraints Western forces face

Demands tactical adaptation in training and readiness



Ukraine shows that under dense ISR, concentration becomes lethal and manoeuvre is exposed
Cornish (2025), Revels (2025) & others caution against uncritical lesson-importation – particularly for drones

Betts (1996), Bronk (2022a), Bronk (2022a, 5:00-6:00), Cornish (2022, 5:40-5:55), King (2023), Kirichenko (2024), Kirichenko (2025), Watling (2020a), Watling (2022b)

If nuclear weapons made wars with great-powers obsolete, then Ukraine would not be fighting one today.

The Russo-Ukrainian War should be treated as a vignette for peer conflict conducted under dense ISR, rapid kill chains and the nuclear shadow.

Nuclear escalation is a threshold – constraining strategy.

But it does not eliminate conventional war.

Within that space, light infantry remain a central component

Combined arms manoeuvre also remains possible –

reinforcing the relevance of the historical parallel.

The consequence of Ukraine is not that its tactics should be copied wholesale, but that it exposes constraints which Western forces could face in similar conditions

Analysts accordingly caution against uncritical lesson-importation,

stressing that armoured and air warfare will remain decisive.

Cornish contends that “too much is made of” technological and drone warfare.

King counters that Ukraine’s, positional, attritional fighting, is not an aberration, but a recurring prelude to manoeuvre –

So its lessons will remain relevant to the west

In WW1, machine guns and artillery punished massed infantry, forcing dispersion and stormtrooper-style infiltration.

As Alan has shown, ubiquitous ISR eliminates the assumption of unseen manoeuvre.

My focus is how infantry adapt tactically and what that implies for command

This does not require the suggested 'doctrinal shift' away from peacekeeping or hybrid warfare.

For as Tony highlighted, the syndicate considers the question mis-framed.

INSTEAD, it requires retraining infantry to survive and manoeuvre under persistent visibility.

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Drones' Dual Roles

Darkness and terrain no longer conceal. Battlefield becomes continuously observable



ISR Platforms

Persistent observation across optical and thermal spectra, day and night, controlled at multiple echelons



Weapon Systems

FPVs, droppers, and loitering munitions convert detection into immediate lethality



Tactical Compression

Sensor-to-shooter cycle collapses to small-unit level
Detection is the immediate prelude to strike



Drones collapse the tactical margin by fusing persistent sensing with immediate strike

[Doogwoof Productions \(2025\)](#), [Kirichenko \(2024\)](#), [Ukraine I. L. \(2025, a-i\)](#), [Veteran 1 \(2026\)](#), [Veteran 2 \(2026\)](#), [Watling and Reynolds \(2024\)](#)

Drones matter because they operate in two complementary roles

that together collapse the margin for error for infantry

First, as ISR platforms, through thermal and optical cameras

Second, as weapons—through FPVs, dropper drones or loitering munitions —
they convert detection into immediate lethality.

Detection is no longer a warning;

it is often the immediate prelude to strike –

particularly for hunter-killer and ambush munitions.

Infantry movement becomes continuously observable,

and any visible concentration rapidly attracts fires.

This dual role explains why the battlefield now feels “transparent” – though Davis cautions against assuming total transparency shall be realised

The key risk is often not the firefight, but movement, as evidenced by the sources listed on screen

That reality forces packeted manoeuvre and turns vehicles into liabilities

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Survivability Logic



1

Dispersion Over Protection

Spacing and signature discipline replace armour
Maximise dispersion, minimise visible concentration

2

Unpredictable Movement

Brief, irregular exposure windows. Control timing
Avoid patterns that attract fires

3

Least Interesting Target

Manoeuvre becomes survival mechanism
Pass through space without drawing attention

Infantry survive by dispersion, minimising targetability and signature discipline, not by cover and concealment

Kirichenko (2024), Kirichenko (2025, a-b), Shatalov (2025), Ukraine I. L. (2025, a-i), Veteran 1 (2026), Veteran 2 (2026), Zadbrodskyi et al. (2022)

Under persistent ISR, survivability is no longer primarily achieved through protection or firepower, but through becoming the least interesting target

Amassing force undetected, is increasingly challenging, per Watling and Davis

For example, Robotic CASEVAC is a less attractive target than a litter of stretcher bearers, per Kirichenko

Primary source interviews report that better equipped foreign legionnaires will attract fire, while conscripts moving on the same path won't,

Infantry adapt by maximising dispersion, camouflage, timing, unpredictability and signature discipline

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Movement Under Persistent ISR

- 1
Concentration and Mass
■ Traditional large units possibly obsolescent under drone air superiority
- 2
Movement Formations
Creating a sense of looming danger
- 3
Dispersed Packets
Groups of 2-3 soldiers moving under mission command.
Maximise 'stop-listen-watch'
- 4
Point Convergence
Independent moves, mass on objective

New Reality

- ■ Traditional Cold War movement forms increasingly untenable **without air superiority**
- Move independently, converge at decisive moments
- Vehicles shuttle to dismount points, then infantry advance on foot (up to 10km)
- Movement causes more casualties than contact itself

Persistent ISR makes movement – not firefights – the primary source of casualties at present

Kirichenko (2025, a-b), Shatalov (2025), Ukraine I. L. (2025, a-j), Veteran 1 (2026), Veteran 2 (2026), Watling and Danylyuk (2024)

Many traditional Cold War movement forms are increasingly unworkable, per the sources cited

2 or more soldiers in proximity often attract fire,

movement in the open will be targeted,

Formations such as combat column are tactically untenable

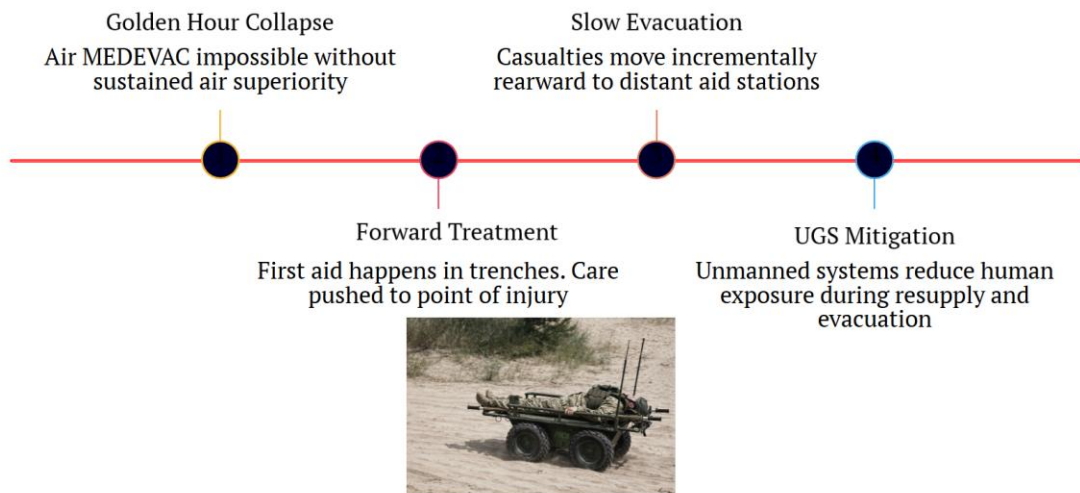
Instead, platoons move as independent and dispersed packets of two or three, converging only at the objective

Vehicles function as shuttles to dismount points.

From there, infantry advance on foot in small teams – often up to 10km.

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Medical and Sustainment



Medical support and sustainment revert to endurance models without air superiority

Bronk (2022b, 5:00-6:00), Hinton (2023), Kirichenko (2025, a-b), Pfeiffer et al. (2024), RAND Corp (2021), Reynolds (2023), Shatalov (2025), **■**i (2026)

Exposure shapes every action.

Logistics carries disproportional risk.

Interviewees report, some conscripts choose prolonged exposure in defence over the risk of movement during relief

Medical care follows the same revision:

Without sustained air superiority, golden-hour extraction becomes impossible.

First aid happens in the trenches;

Casualties move slowly to the rear

Commanders such as Shatalov, report that a majority of resupply and CASEVAC is achieved via robotics

Until the technology matures however, UGS remain peripheral for offence

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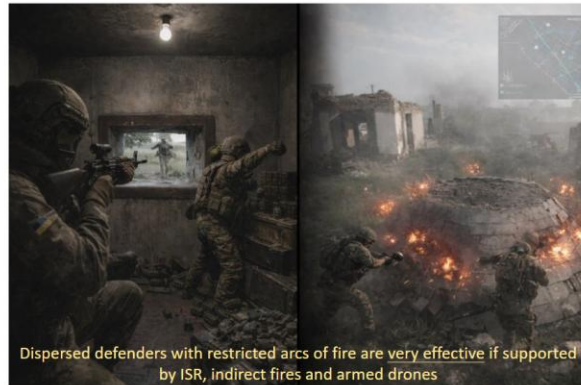
Role Differentiation in Positional (Trench) Warfare

Functional Split: Echoes stormtrooper task differentiation, not massed assault

Western cover-from-view mindset fails. FPVs penetrate buildings, vehicles, bunkers – threats emerge from any axis

**Defenders**
Endurance focus: dispersed positions, fire discipline, integrated indirect fires to fix and attrit

**Assaulters**
Highly trained: speed, aggression, initiative, small-team coordination. Infiltrate weak points



In positional warfare: Infantry roles divide into defenders who endure and assaulters who infiltrate
Russia fields Infantry unit types: disposable; line; assault; and specialised

Cornish (2022, 5:40-5:55), French (2022, 9:52-10:50), Fox (2023, 10:44-15:45), Shatalov (2025), Molvin (2025), Veteran 1 (2026), Veteran 2 (2026), Watling (2022b, 30:00-31:00), Watling and Reynolds (2025)

Persistent ISR and precision fires have driven a functional split in infantry roles which is historically familiar

Defenders focus on endurance: occupying dispersed, hardened positions, maintaining fire discipline and using indirect and unmanned fires to fix and attrit the enemy.

Assaulters, by contrast, must be highly trained.

They rely on speed, aggression, initiative, and mission command to infiltrate, identify weak points, and conduct assaults in very small teams.

This role split echoes stormtrooper task differentiation

As Cornish and French argue, protection against a technologically-enabled force comes from speed and out-ranging it.

In a drone-saturated battlespace, perhaps the infantry's most effective role may no longer be to close with but rather to destroy the enemy through unmanned fires.

The traditional Western mindset of, cover from view and, cover from fire fails, when threats emerge from any angle and FPV drones can follow your path

Importantly, Western professional forces largely retained the assaulter skill set through GWOT and SOF influence, including decentralised tactical execution

Counterinsurgency centralised operational authority out of legal necessity. That reflex now sits uneasily with the demands of peer warfare.

However, conventional infantry and manoeuvre doctrine endured beneath the surface

it needs operational renewal and tactical evolution.

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Mission Command

Shared Feeds ■ Empty Micromanagement
ISR stresses mission command, doesn't remove it. Centralised control increases casualties · classic Soviet failure pattern

Initiative Migrates Downward

Decisive action sits with lance corporals and corporals leading

Senior Role Separation

Platoon commanders plan and coordinate fires.
Cannot directly control assault once begun

■ Training Demand Increases

Junior leaders must interpret intent, navigate independently, recognise opportunities under information overload



Mission command survives, but initiative must migrate downward to remain viable

Alach (2008a), Alach (2008b), Betts (1996), Krepinevich (1994), Veteran 1 (2026), Veteran 2 (2026), Watling and Reynolds (2024), Zadbrodskyi et al. (2022)

Contemporary war amplifies the need for mission command, per Alach, Betts, Cohen and Krepinevich.

Shared drone feeds enable initiative, but tempt micromanagement

Indeed Zabrodskyi and colleagues linked much of Russia's early invasion failure to weak junior leader empowerment.

The result is higher Russian and conscript-Ukrainian casualties

Veterans report that the storm trooper tactics are incompatible with centralised command

On both sides, effective light infantry action, increasingly sits with lance corporals and corporals

Platoon commanders and sergeants retain an essential role in advance planning and coordinating fires,

but they cannot meaningfully control the battle once it begins.

This significantly raises training demands:

junior NCOs and privates must interpret intent, navigate independently and recognise opportunities.

The training of smaller, professional post-Cold War military lends

itself well to these demands, per Schloesser, Strand and the US Army

However, Watling and Reynolds caution against concluding that command above small-unit level has been nullified,

arguing that Russian performance is shaped by severe officer shortfalls,

leaving unresolved the degree to which properly trained leadership could still shape the tactical battle.

The doctrine of mission command endures, but executing it under continuous visibility requires far greater competence at the lowest levels.

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Organising principles

01

Decentralise ISR

Most effective when pushed to platoon level for local awareness and initiative

02

Mass Weaponised Drones

FPVs and droppers concentrated in dedicated units, repositioned for decisive effect

03

UGS Mitigate Movement Risk

Enable resupply and CASEVAC without exposing soldiers. Not yet decisive for offensive manoeuvre

While Western militaries retained doctrine, Melchior (2026) cautions they risk obsolescence against those who have accelerated their kill chains



Drones contest manoeuvre warfare. While CUAS may sustain manoeuvre supremacy, the character of light infantry combat's increasingly attritional, potentially necessitating a move toward stand-off tactics (Revels & Uribe, 2025)

The problem is execution under sensor saturation, not doctrinal abandonment

Some organisational principles emerges from this tactical adaptation.

ISR is most effective when decentralised and is pushed down to platoon level, to support local awareness and initiative.

In contrast, fires achieve greater effect when concentrated in dedicated units that can be massed and repositioned to deliver decisive effects,

Echoing historical lessons from machine-gun employment and interwar armoured doctrine.

Unmanned ground systems have not yet proven decisive for offensive manoeuvre,

But they are essential to sustain the defence – which enables subsequent combined arms manoeuvre, per Kirichenko.

Since the 1990s, Western militaries did not abandon doctrine;

they focused elsewhere and lost currency - particularly at the operational level

However, basic training never abandoned combat fundamentals, per Jennings.

Instead, COIN and PSO were layered on – still evidenced within our Military College

High-intensity training builds adaptable junior leaders who are equipped to excel across conflict spectra.

While PSO and COIN skills are specific, the competence required for high-intensity below-nuclear threshold war, scales down.

The inverse test fails: low-intensity centralised command doesn't survive peer on peer war

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No Fundamental Shift Required – TTPs Must Evolve

Doctrine Largely Intact
Western mission command and infantry skills map directly to peer assaulter roles. Just not trained for ISR saturation

Character Has Changed
Dispersion and speed beats concentration. Requires TTP evolution and resourced repetition, not doctrinal reinvention

Training Time Binding
Peer-war competence scales downward to PSO. Inverse fails. Constraint is infrastructure and time, not curriculum choice



Without counter-UAS doctrine, TTPs and capability "risks sustained exposure to precision fires, producing and unacceptable rate of equipment loss", per Watling and Danylyuk (2024)

These infantry adaptations create edge conditions for combined arms reconstitution

The problem is execution capacity under sensor saturation, necessitating evolution not doctrinal abandonment

Cornish (2024), French (2022), Melchior (2026), Watling and Danylyuk (2024)

Hence, Western doctrinal fundamentals endure, by must adapt

Dispersion now defeats concentration, demanding evolution

However, it reveals the 'Infantry Ceiling': They are not decisive.

They constitute survivable packets, which navigate as 'uninteresting targets,'

detecting, harassing, attritting, and blocking to create conditions for combined arms reconstitution.

Pat will now show how we weave armour, fires, and engineers into the decisive mass for high-intensity combined arms manoeuvre below the nuclear threshold

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